

docs_chain

Revision: 2 **Last modified:** 2026-05-29T09:30:00Z **Status:** Docs Chain Phases 1-3 IMPLEMENTED + tested (internal/hash + internal/graph + internal/adaptor + internal/orchestrator — go test ./... passes). Phases 4-7 PLANNED per the plan. This README and the docs under docs/ mark each capability IMPLEMENTED vs PLANNED and do not claim working behaviour that is not yet built (§11.4.6). **Authority:** Operator mandate 2026-05-29 (docs_chain initiative)

docs_chain is a universal, Go-implemented, **bidirectional document-and-database dependency-propagation engine**. When any member of a registered chain changes — a Markdown source, an HTML/PDF export, or a SQLite database — docs_chain detects the change by **content hash** (not mtime) and propagates it through every connected member in every declared direction, regenerating and re-exporting atomically, so no tracked artefact can fall out of sync.

It is the mechanical successor to the project’s ad-hoc documentation-sync scripts. It ships as its own vasic-digital submodule and is consumed as a core part of the HelixConstitution submodule so any project adopts it out of the box and registers its own chains via per-context YAML.

Model in one line

Salsa-style content-hashed incremental recomputation over a DAG, with Kahn topological ordering, early-cutoff, declared-authority bidirectional sync edges, and atomic-rename + SQLite-transaction commit.

Implementation status

Phase	Scope	Status
0	Research + design + this documentation	Done (design artefacts)
1		

Phase	Scope	Status
	Core DAG + content-hash engine	IMPLEMENTED + tested (internal/hash, internal/graph)
2	Node adapters + transforms	IMPLEMENTED + tested (internal/adaptor)
3	Propagation orchestrator + atomicity (filesystem/SQLite)	IMPLEMENTED + tested (internal/orchestrator)
4	Config-driven multi-context + CLI/daemon	PLANNED
5	Comprehensive test suite (beyond the Phase 1-3 package tests)	PLANNED
6	Constitution-submodule integration + repo creation	PLANNED — OPERATOR-GATED
7	ATMOSphere wiring + retire ad-hoc scripts	PLANNED

What is **IMPLEMENTED** today (go test ./... passes)

- **internal/hash** — Hasher interface + ByteContentHasher (LF normalization, trailing-whitespace strip, single trailing newline) so semantically-equivalent inputs collide by design; plus the sorted member-list fingerprint for roster/corpus sidecars (§11.4.86). Change detection is by **content hash, never mtime**.
- **internal/graph** — the DAG (Node/Edge/Graph), Validate (cycle detection → CycleError), TopoOrder (deterministic Kahn ordering), and the recompute engine: Recompute (early-cutoff — unchanged inputs skip transform), ResolveSync (declared-authority bidirectional sync edges with ConflictError), and CommitHashes. An in-memory Store (MemStore) backs the unit tests.
- **internal/adaptor** (Phase 2) — node-content adapters backing real stores: a FileAdapter for markdown (and the on-disk html/pdf/docx outputs) with per-file atomic temp-then-rename writes; DERIVED transforms that shell out to **pandoc** (md→html, md→docx) and **weasyprint** (html→pdf) — when a tool is absent they return a typed ToolAbsentError (IsToolAbsent) and never fake success; a SQLiteAdapter (pure-Go modernc.org/sqlite, no

cgo) whose hashed content is a **canonical row dump** from a deterministic ORDER BY query — NOT the raw .db page bytes — so identical row sets collide regardless of insert order; and a FileStore implementing the Phase-1 graph.Store interface on top of these adapters, so graph.Recompute runs unmodified against real files and databases.

- **internal/orchestrator** (Phase 3) — Run ties graph.Recompute to the FileStore with three guarantees: **atomicity** (regenerated outputs are staged in-memory and written only after the whole run succeeds; any transform error rolls back with zero partial writes — composes with §9.2), **cycle-guard** (refuses to run when graph.Validate reports a CycleError, writing nothing), and **sync-conflict** surfacing (ConflictError on a both-dirty sync pair, writing nothing). It returns the RecomputeResult plus a committed / rolled-back / in-sync / conflict / cycle Status. A staged intermediate feeds the next transform, so multi-level chains (md→html→pdf) propagate in one pass.

What is PLANNED (NOT yet functional — do not assume working behaviour)

The cmd/ CLI/daemon, per-context YAML config loading, the comprehensive beyond-package test suite, and the constitution-submodule integration are owned by Phases 4-7 and are NOT implemented in this repo yet. The docs/ pages describe their DESIGNED contract.

Documentation

Document	Purpose
docs/ARCHITECTURE.md	In-depth system architecture — DAG model, content-hash detection, early-cutoff, Kahn propagation, bidirectional sync authority + conflicts, atomicity/crash-safety, SQLite integration. Mermaid + ASCII diagrams.
docs/USER_GUIDE.md	End-to-end adoption guide — prerequisites, build, init .docs_chain/, define a context, run sync, the watch daemon, conflict resolution, CI integration.
docs/CONFIG_SCHEMA.md	Formal per-context YAML reference — every field, type, allowed values, defaults,

Document	Purpose
docs/USE_CASE_CATALOGUE.md	validation rules; annotated derive-from + sync examples. Living registry of 8 ready-to-use chain recipes (issues, fixed, status, roster/corpus, changelog, README doc-link, universal markdown-export, CONTINUATION).
docs/CONSTITUTION_INTEGRATION.md	How the constitution submodule makes docs_chain available to every consuming project — inheritance model, config discovery, the §11.4.x anchors it satisfies, what a project gets for free vs must register.

Quick start (Phase 1 core engine)

```
git clone git@github.com:vasic-digital/docs_chain.git
cd docs_chain
go test ./...           # internal/hash + internal/graph – all green
```

The library API today is consumed programmatically (the cmd/ CLI is Phase 4). Minimal use of the implemented core:

```
import (
    "digital.vasic.docs_chain/internal/graph"
    "digital.vasic.docs_chain/internal/hash"
)

g := graph.New()
// AddNode for each member, AddEdge for derive-from / sync
// relationships,
// then g.Validate() (cycle check) and g.TopoOrder() (Kahn
// ordering).
res, err := g.Recompute(store, hash.NewByteContentHasher(),
    transforms)
// res reports which targets changed (early-cutoff skips unchanged
// inputs);
// g.CommitHashes(res) persists the new content hashes.
```

See [docs/USER_GUIDE.md](#) for the full DESIGNED workflow and [docs/CONFIG_SCHEMA.md](#) for the per-context YAML contract.

License

Part of the vasic-digital toolkit. Distributed under the same terms as the surrounding vasic-digital / HelixConstitution submodule family.

Design provenance

The authoritative Phase-0 design (DESIGN / RESEARCH / PLAN) lives in the consuming project's research tree at docs/research/docs_chain/ and is mirrored into the consuming project, not into this standalone repo. The docs/ pages here are the self-contained, comprehensive specification of the DESIGNED system.